But why let the sad song play

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42698946.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra)

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Mild Spinnetossa, cameos by other characters, Hurt/Comfort, Fluff, Growing Up, alcohol use, Catra has chronic pain, Everyone's kind of a dork around the sad stuff, Spinnetossa mom-ing intensifies

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But why let the sad song play

by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

Catra didn't like her birthday.

She learned at a very early age that her birthday didn't matter. Her mother had informed her that *being born* wasn't a reason to celebrate. It was nothing special. People much better than her were born every single day. People who would go on to accomplish far more than she would ever be capable of. What did *she* need a celebration for?

-OR-

Catra's birthday throughout the years. A companion piece to *I have face it, a life wasted*.

Notes

This is set in the same universe as my story I have faced it, a life wasted, so you miiiiiiiiiight want to read that for some context on things that are mentioned throughout the story: https://archiveofourown.org/works/27928786/chapters/68395099

the tldr is that Catra developed a very BAD alcohol problem at a young age to escape her crappy home life, and while driving home drunk one night got into an accident with Adora in the car. Things happen, they don't see each other for eight years. And Melog is a service dog.

Trigger warnings here for alcohol abuse, mentions of withdrawal.

See the end of the work for more notes

Age Six

Catra didn't like her birthday.

She learned at a very early age that her birthday didn't matter. Her mother had informed her that *being born* wasn't a reason to celebrate. It was nothing special. People much better than her were born every single day. People who would go on to accomplish far more than she would ever be capable of. What did *she* need a celebration for?

Catra learned not to expect anything. Her first grade teacher put everyone's birthdays up on a calendar at the front of the classroom, and sometimes kids brought in snacks to share with the class. Catra scoffed at the idea of her mother doing that for *her*. She barely remembered to *feed* Catra half the time.

The new girl—Adora, who enjoyed sharing her carrot sticks with her for some reason—was *shocked* when she realized Catra's birthday was coming up.

"Birthdays are important!" she insisted one day during snack time.

"Birthdays are *stupid*," Catra grumbled, shoving a carrot stick in her mouth. "And my mom's not going to do anything for it anyway, so nobody is going to care."

The only kids who got birthday acknowledgments were the ones who brought in treats. Everyone else was left in the dust.

Adora didn't seem capable of accepting that.

"It's *your* birthday, so it's important," she insisted. Catra just rolled her eyes.

"Whatever."

She woke up early the morning of her birthday, unable to quench that small hope that maybe, just maybe, her mother would change her mind. But no, of course. Her bagged lunch was waiting for her on the counter when she got downstairs after getting herself ready for school. A sandwich, a juicebox, and carrot sticks. She sighed, tucked the bag into her backpack, and left the house, heading for the bus stop.

Adora, surprisingly, didn't mention her birthday at all. Catra was grateful. Maybe she had realized why it was stupid. Good.

Lunchtime came. Adora always bought lunch, so Catra grabbed their usual table in the back and started eating.

"Happy birthday!"

Catra jumped, surprised, and looked up to see Adora holding two big cookies – the ones from the snack bar that cost like a dollar each.

"What?"

"I know you said it's not a big deal, but it *is*," Adora said, sitting and shoving one of the cookies at Catra. "I can't buy cookies for the whole class, but I can buy one for you and one for me. We can celebrate together."

Catra stared at her in disbelief. "Where did you get the money for cookies?"

"I skipped lunch, remember?"

Oh yeah, Catra *did* remember splitting her sandwich with Adora couple times. She'd said her foster parents had forgotten to give her lunch money.

"Okay," Catra finally said, smiling a little. "But no singing."

"Fiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiine. No singing. Let's eat!"

It was the best birthday of Catra's entire life.

Age Fourteen

It wasn't a birthday party in *name*. Scorpia knew Catra hated those. It was just a party that happened to fall on Catra's birthday and happened to have Catra's favorite cake flavor. That was all. No one dared to sing happy birthday.

But someone *did* bring alcohol.

"Seriously?" Adora asked in disbelief. "Are you drinking *again*?"

"Lighten up," Catra said, waving Adora off and taking a long sip of the cheapest beer somebody had bribed an adult to buy. "It's my birthday."

"Like you've *ever* cared about your birthday."

"I do when it's an excuse to drink."

She knew Adora was worried. Her alcohol consumption had been a little… *liberal* since an end-of-summer party a few months prior. It wasn't *her* fault it made her feel so good. Adora was just no fun.

Someone said something about jello shots, and Catra was immediately off the couch and running into the kitchen. Adora followed at a sedate pace. Honestly, what was there to worry about? She was just having a little fun. Being drunk even made her mother more bearable. Alcohol was practically a miracle.

"Hey Wildcat!" Scorpia called as they entered the kitchen with several other people (including fucking Sparkles and Arrow Boy. Who invited *them* to Catra's not-birthday party?).

"Yo. I heard jello shots?"

Adora stayed back, shaking her head a little. But she didn't say no when Catra handed her one.

"Come on Adora, lighten up. It's my birthday!"

"Okay , okay. But we're not making a habit of this. Got it?"

"Got it. Drink up!"

Age Nineteen

Being drunk wasn't fun anymore.

It was more of an obligation than anything. Being drunk numbed the pain, mental and physical. She could almost stand on her fucked up knee without it hurting, and if she was drunk enough, she didn't have any nightmares.

"Catra?"

She whirled to look at the two bewildered women behind her. "Spinnetossa! Wait. Netrella?"

Spinnerella and Netossa exchanged concerned looks. "What's up, Kat?" Netossa asked slowly .

"It's my birthday!" Catra giggled, taking a long swig of the vodka bottle she'd co-opted. It was a frat party . No one was monitoring the alcohol.

"Well, happy birthday. You should've told us, we'd have gotten a cake."

Catra laughed again. "I've never had a cake, ya know . Like that whole singing happy birthday, blowing out the candles shpeal? Never had it. My mom ~~I told~~ you she sucks, right? ~~She~~ she never gave me a party or anything. I had a friend who would buy me

cookies and cupcakes and stuff, and another one who just *happened* to throw parties on or near my birthday and included a cake with my favorite flavor. This is more fun anyway."

She took another sip, beaming at the women. She didn't know them very well—she'd just met them at the beginning of the year, when she'd tentatively started attending campus Pride meetings, thinking maybe she *wasn't* as straight as she had once thought. It was quite the realization. She thought she was handling it pretty well, though.

"Right, can I um...can I have that?" Netossa asked slowly, reaching for the bottle. Catra stepped back, taking one more long pull off it, and finally surrendered it. "How much have you had to drink?"

"It's my birthday!" Catra protested, pouting. "I can drink as much as I want."

"Absolutely," Netossa agreed. "I just think maybe as much as you want might not be the healthiest."

"Do you come to parties *just* to be killjoys?"

"Yes." Spinnerella wrapped an arm around Catra's shoulders, turning her toward the door. "We look for wayward baby gays and make sure they get home safe when they're too drunk to function."

"I am *not* too drunk to function," Catra grumbled, pulling away to steal a shot from someone about three times her size. No one was fast enough to stop her from downing the vile concoction in one long sip. "See? I can still steal shit from giant idiots. Perfectly fine."

Netossa quickly took the glass away, handed it back to the pissed off guy, and shoved Spinnerella and Catra away. "Yeah, let's get you somewhere else, kid."

Catra stuck her tongue out at the guy before he was out of sight. "You get the car," Netossa said, taking Catra's arm to hold her close. "I'll wait with this one. I doubt she can walk that far."

Catra scoffed. "I'm not a *lightweight*."

"Trust me, that is *not* what I'm worried about."

Spinnerella headed down the street, and Catra leaned on Netossa, because why not? She was holding Catra there, she might as well be useful. "You're just like Adora," she said after a moment. The thought made her sad. "She was stupid and gay too."

"Adora?" Netossa repeated. "Your friend? The one who kissed you?"

Catra nodded, eyes fixed on the ground. "She always took care of me too. I used to sneak into her room to spend nights at her house when I didn't want to be home. Her foster parents didn't like me, so sometimes I just slept in the closet, especially if I was going to wake up hungover."

"I doubt—"

"No, her foster parents *hated* me. So did her foster sister. They're all rich, stuck-up bitches and I was never good enough to darken their doorstep."

"They sound like assholes."

Catra snorted. "They totally are. But fuck 'em. *Adora* liked me. I didn't need anyone else's approval."

A car pulled up to the sidewalk. Netossa patted Catra's back and helped her into the backseat. "All right, kiddo. Let's get you home."

Age Twenty-Two

Getting sober *sucked*.

Catra felt shaky as she pulled her blankets over her head, blocking out the offensive sun. How dare it be so bright? Who fucking allowed

that?

A knock at the door distracted her from her own woes and sorrows. "Got breakfast for you," Spinnerella said as she let herself in. Catra couldn't really protest – it was *their* guest room. Catra just mostly lived in it. "Just some eggs and toast, don't worry. I know you're not feeling well."

"Happy fucking birthday to me," Catra grumbled, dragging herself out from under the blankets. Spinnerella gave her a gentle, sympathetic smile.

"I know. Come on, you need to eat."

"*Fiiiiiine*." Catra sat up, rubbing her eyes. "You're the *worst*, though."

"The absolute worst, I know."

Okay, that wasn't *really* true. Catra was just in a *really* bad mood. Spinnerella and Netossa had been nothing but good to her over the last couple months, since her mother had finally kicked her out. They seemed *more* than happy to do what Sharon Weaver had utterly failed at – giving Catra a loving parental figure.

"I still don't get why you guys are so nice to me," she mumbled, taking a bite of scrambled eggs. Spinnerella kissed the top of her head, smiling.

"You don't have to understand it. Just accept it."

Catra harumphed, shoving her half-heartedly. Spinnerella just laughed.

Age Twenty-Six

Twenty-six years. That was how long it took for Catra to get her first *real* birthday party, complete with embarrassing singing and

everything.

"*Happy birthday to you* ooooooooooooooooooou!" Netossa drew out the last word long after Spinnerella and Frosta had stopped singing. Catra had hid her face in her hands, wish desperately to disappear into the ground. Melog nudged her knee as if to say *dont die, I just got here*. She still wasnt very used to having the dog at her side at all times.

"I hate you all," Catra muttered. "So much."

"Hey ." Frosta pushed her shoulder . "Y ou gotta blow out the candles. There's a lot, so try not to run out of breath."

"Ex *cuse* me?" Catra looked up, horrified, while Netossa and Spinnerella burst out laughing. "Are you calling me *old*?"

"Y eah, arent you thirty or something?"

"I'm *twenty-six*!" Catra grabbed her cane and jumped up, fully intent on beating Frosta with it (okay not really), but Netossa shoved her back into her seat.

"Come on birthday girl, make a wish."

Catra looked around the kitchen, smiling wistfully. She didnt really have any wishes. Not any *practical* ones anyway. Her knee would never get better. She was never going to see Adora again. She could never fix how much she had fucked things up.

But her life was pretty good. She didnt need a wish.

She blew out the candles (in *one breath*, thank you very much).

Age Thirty

Nothing big. That was all Catra had asked. She didn't care that she was thirty, she just wanted to have a nice day, maybe go to her favorite restaurant, definitely spend some time with Adora. That was all. She didn't need anything else.

She *certainly* didn't need a big celebratory dinner at Angella's and Micah's giant house.

"We promised not to sing happy birthday, didn't we? Stop pouting."

Catra glared at her *kind of* sister-in-law. Glimmer still called herself Adora's sister, even if her parents had never officially adopted her. And since Adora and Catra were married, Catra was now Glimmer's sister (*in-law*, Catra repeatedly added insistently).

Melog was taking the night off, assured that Catra was surrounded by people who would be more than happy to help her, and was in the corner, chewing on a bone Micah had bought for him. Micah was *delighted* by the semi-regular presence of a dog in his house. He'd apparently been begging Angella for one for *years*.

"Who's going to eat all of this cake?" Catra asked, gesturing at the absurd cake on the table.

"I'm *sure* we'll manage," Bow said, patting his belly. Catra shook her head at all of them, leaning over to rest her head on Adora's shoulder. These people were exhausting.

"All right, well I'm cutting this thing," Netossa said, grabbing a knife. "Who wants what?"

"Can I have a corner piece?" Castaspella asked brightly.

"I want the piece with Melog on it!" Frosta added.

"All of you shush," Angella scolded them. "Catra gets first choice."

"But she's going to take *forever* to choose."

"Nope." Catra popped her lips on the P . "I want the piece with Melog on it."

Frosta slammed her hands down on the table. "You're doing that on *purpose*!"

"Damn right, Snowflake."

She gave Frosta the piece, of course. She didn't care what slice of cake she had. She was just happy to be where she was. With people who loved her. With her *wife*. And that was still fresh enough to make Catra laugh. She slid her free hand into her pocket, fingering the shiny new three-year coin Huntara had tossed at her a few weeks earlier.

"You okay?" Adora asked, kissing the top of her head. Catra looked up at her, and grinned.

"Yeah. I'm great."

End Notes

Istill think about this universe a lot, clearly <3

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!